

Duke - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-caliber with a credible top-30 offensive path around RB Nate Sheppard, TE Jeremiah Hasley and Jonathan Brewer's system, but a new starting quarterback, 17 lost starters and an already-vulnerable defense make Duke one of the more fragile mid-tier Power 4 evaluations.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · SP+ No. 45
Returning production	50% (No. 79) overall · Off. 49% (No. 86) · Def. 51% (No. 73)
Primer power rating	+5.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.4 wins · likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse - Worse and materially less stable: Duke returns a few high-leverage offensive/defensive anchors, but it replaces the starting quarterback, three starting receivers, three starting offensive linemen and major contributors at every defensive level.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: OC Jonathan Brewer's spread offense leans on RB Nate Sheppard, TE Jeremiah Hasley and C Matt Craycraft with San José State transfer QB Walker Eget now named the starter. HC Manny Diaz and DC Jonathan Patke retain the Multiple defense, but every level is replacing major contributors from a unit that already struggled with efficiency and explosives.

Bottom line: Duke has enough offensive anchors and staff continuity to reach another bowl, but 6-6 is safer because QB Walker Eget is unproven at this level, both lines are rebuilding and the defense must improve amid heavy turnover.

Beats expectations if: QB Walker Eget is competent, the rebuilt OL lets RB Nate Sheppard/TE Jeremiah Hasley carry the offense and the defense sharply improves explosive prevention.

Disappoints if: Seventeen lost starting roles overwhelm the rebuild, offensive efficiency falls with the new QB/WR/OL groups and the new front cannot fix poor defensive success/explosive rates.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB decision:** San José State transfer QB Walker Eget has been named Duke's starting quarterback for the opener.
- 2 Defense:** Duke's spring prospectus lists only four returning offensive starters and four returning defensive starters, with 17 total lost starters including specialists.
- 3 Backfield:** RB Nate Sheppard returns after 1,132 rushing yards and 11 touchdowns, while TE Jeremiah Hasley and C Matt Craycraft are established returning offensive anchors.
- 4 National baseline:** The defense allowed explosive plays at a No.126 national rate and success at a No.105 rate in 2025; SP+ projects the 2026 defense only No.81.
- 5 ? Key uncertainty:** Duke had 13 players pursue professional football after 2025 plus material eligibility/graduation losses, making the turnover broader than the portal alone.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-5 (7-2 ACC)	● Good
Scoring	34.6 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	423.5 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	138.1 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	7.90 YPA · 34 TD / 6 INT	● Very good
Third downs	39.0%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	29.4 PPG allowed	● Below average
Total defense	424.2 YPG allowed	● Very poor
Rush defense	147.4 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	276.8 YPG · 8.37 YPA · 21 TD allowed	● Poor

Duke’s 2025 offense was pass-driven and productive, while the run game lagged. The defense was the clear weakness, especially in total yardage and pass efficiency.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.06 · No. 33	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.097 · No. 30	● Very good
Off. success rate	44.7% · No. 45	● Good / above average
Off. explosive-play rate	12.8% · No. 51	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	14.4% · No. 54	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.67 · No. 61	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.044 · No. 84	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	44.3% · No. 105	● Below average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	14.3% · No. 126	● Very poor
Havoc created	16.5% · No. 48	● Good / above average

Advanced-stat read: The offense’s No. 30 EPA/play and No. 33 opponent-adjusted rating confirm real quality despite a middling run game. Defensively, poor EPA, success rate and explosive prevention overwhelmed otherwise useful havoc creation.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Manny Diaz - returning	● ↔ Head-coach continuity stabilizes a roster undergoing major turnover.
OC/QB / offensive play caller	Jonathan Brewer - returning	● ↔ Play-calling continuity preserves the spread system while QB and surrounding starters change.
DC/LB	Jonathan Patke - returning	● ↔ Scheme continuity helps, but the exact defensive caller remains unresolved amid major personnel replacement.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Walker Eget	San José State	● ↔ Experienced transfer who has won the starting job; Power 4 translation remains the uncertainty.
◆ RB CJ Campbell Jr.	Rutgers	● ↔ Credible complement behind established RB Nate Sheppard.
◆ WR Javen Nicholas	Charlotte	● ↔ Biletnikoff-recognized transfer projects for a major role in the rebuilt room.
◆ OL Nick Del Grande	Coastal Carolina	● ↔ Another experienced transfer and leading tackle candidate on a line replacing three starters.

Out	To	Loss
QB Darian Mensah	Miami	● ↓ Starting-QB loss creates the Eget/Mahan competition.
WR Cooper Barkate	Miami	● ↓ Starting-receiver loss in a complete primary-WR rebuild.
WR Que'Sean Brown	Virginia Tech	● ↓ Another 2025 starting receiver departs.
WR Sahmir Hagans	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ The third 2025 starting receiver leaves for professional football.
OL Brian Parker II	NFL (Cincinnati), Round 6, No. 189	● ↓ Starting-tackle loss removes a major 2025 OL piece.
OL Bruno Fina	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Starting-OL loss compounds the rebuild.
OL Justin Pickett	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Third starting-OL loss deepens final-five uncertainty.

Offense net: RB Nate Sheppard, TE Jeremiah Hasley and C Matt Craycraft are anchors, but replacing the starting QB, three WR starters and three OL starters makes 2025-level efficiency high variance. ● ↓

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DT Owen Wafle	Penn State	● ↔ Interior-rotation addition replacing DT Josiah Green and DT Aaron Hall.
◆ DT Dakota Quiñonez	Dartmouth	● ↔ Adds an interior option without replacing the lost starting experience.
◆ S Patrick Smith-Young	North Texas	● ↔ Starting/major safety candidate alongside returning S DaShawn Stone.

Out	To	Loss
DE Wesley Williams	NFL (Jacksonville), Round 4, No. 119	● ↓ Fourth-round edge loss is central to the front rebuild.
DE Vincent Anthony Jr.	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Second starting-edge loss removes more front experience.
DT Josiah Green	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Starting-DT loss increases newcomer dependence.
DT Aaron Hall	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Second starting-interior loss further reduces continuity.
CB Chandler Rivers	NFL (Baltimore), Round 5, No. 162	● ↓ Fifth-round corner loss removes a prominent secondary starter.
S Caleb Weaver	Undrafted; rookie-minicamp opportunity	● ↓ Starting-safety loss follows a rookie-minicamp path, not confirmed NFL roster membership.
LB Tre Freeman	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Starting-LB loss via eligibility/graduation removes more second-level experience.

Defense net: Returning LB Luke Mergott and secondary anchors provide a spine, but front/LB losses are severe for a defense already poor in success rate and explosive prevention. ● ↓

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	OC Jonathan Brewer's spread attack rebuilds around named starter QB Walker Eget, RB Nate Sheppard, TE Jeremiah Hasley and C Matt Craycraft.	Proven RB/TE production and center continuity support a 2025 top-30 EPA offense.	Eget's Power 4 transition, protection and receiver separation after losing the starting QB, three WR starters and three OL starters.
Defense	Diaz/Patke keep the Multiple structure around LB Luke Mergott and returning secondary anchors while rebuilding the front.	Linebacker/secondary continuity and useful havoc creation provide a base.	Poor explosive prevention and down-to-down efficiency if the new front cannot replace major departures quickly.
Special teams	Returning punter with unsettled placekicking and long snapping.	The punter is settled and SP+ rates the unit No. 36.	No established field-goal/PAT winner and no returning starting long snapper.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	QB Walker Eget has won the job, but his Power 4 transition still controls the offensive floor.
RB	● B+	● ↔	High	RB Nate Sheppard returns after 1,132 rushing yards and 11 TD as the safest high-volume piece.
WR	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Javen Nicholas leads a room replacing all three listed 2025 starters.
TE	● A–	● ↔	High	TE Jeremiah Hasley's recognition and starting experience make him central to the rebuilt passing game.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	C Matt Craycraft is the stable anchor on an OL replacing three starters.
DL/Edge	● C	● ↓	Medium-low	Multiple starting front losses hit a unit already poor at down-to-down and explosive-play prevention.
LB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	LB Luke Mergott is the clearest returning front-seven anchor amid heavy turnover.
Secondary	● B–	● ↓	Medium	CB Landan Callahan supplies continuity while CB Chandler Rivers and S Caleb Weaver are replaced.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	Placekicker is unsettled and the starting long snapper must be replaced.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	Returning HC Manny Diaz and OC Jonathan Brewer provide important continuity during a major roster reset.
Overall	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	Bowl-caliber, but a new starting QB, 17 lost starters and a vulnerable defense make Duke unusually fragile.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Walker Eget (TR: San José State)	QB	● Unproven Power 4 starter	-	Named Duke's opener starter; his translation from San José State is the main quarterback variable.
Dan Mahan	QB	● Reserve quarterback / developmental upside	-	Finished behind Eget in the starting competition and remains an important reserve option.
Nate Sheppard	RB	● High-end Power 4 feature back	Maxwell	Returns after 1,132 rushing yards and 11 touchdowns and is Duke's safest high-volume offensive piece.
Jeremiah Hasley	TE	● High-end conference tight end	ACC preseason first team · John Mackey	Forced Players-to-Know recognition plus extensive starting experience makes him a central target in the rebuilt passing game.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Matt Craycraft	C	● High-end conference center	Rimington	Returning starting center and the most stable anchor on an OL replacing three starters.
◆ Javen Nicholas (TR: Charlotte)	WR	● High-upside major-role receiver	Biletnikoff	Charlotte transfer is the most recognized candidate in a receiver room replacing all three listed 2025 starters.
Luke Mergott	LB	● High-end returning linebacker	Butkus	The clearest returning front-seven anchor after Duke lost multiple linebackers and defenders who moved to professional football.
Landan Callahan	CB	● Solid returning Power 4 starter	-	One of the four returning defensive starters and a key continuity piece in a secondary replacing Chandler Rivers and Caleb Weaver.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Manageable for bowl contention, but the rebuild needs to settle before a difficult late stretch featuring road Miami and home Clemson.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 53
Hardest stretch	at NC State → at Miami → Clemson → at Wake Forest
Swing games	at Georgia Tech, North Carolina, at Virginia, at NC State, at Wake Forest
Advantage	The bye follows the four-game opening block, giving the new quarterback/OL/defensive rotations a reset before the ACC sequence begins.
Expected	6.4 wins · likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 9-5 record can overstate stability given 50% returning production and 17 lost starters, though SP+ still sees mid-tier Power 4 strength.
Back them when	The QB winner proves functional, the OL settles and OC Jonathan Brewer can lean on RB Nate Sheppard/TE Jeremiah Hasley against defenses that do not force passing downs.
Fade/pass when	Eget struggles or the OL remains unsettled, or when efficient explosive offenses can attack a rebuilt front and a defense that ranked No. 126 in explosive prevention.
Key monitor	Walker Eget's early efficiency, final OL five, WR hierarchy, defensive rotations, placekicker, exact defensive game-day caller
Week 1 baseline	Duke -12.0 vs. Tulane · rating-only: Duke +5.5 minus Tulane SP+ proxy -4.3 plus 2.0 home field = 11.8, rounded to 0.5; no matchup/availability adjustment. Live market: Duke -9.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Duke's bowl case starts with RB Nate Sheppard, TE Jeremiah Hasley, C Matt Craycraft and OC Jonathan Brewer's continuity. Named starter QB Walker Eget now controls whether the Blue Devils can remain productive despite major turnover.

The risk is concentrated in the rebuilt lines and a defense that already struggled with efficiency and explosives before losing major contributors. Six wins is the safer center, with upside if the QB and front-seven transitions settle quickly.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [camp / roles](#) · [scheme](#) · [departures](#) · [team source](#) · [team source 2](#) · [team source 3](#) · [QB1 update](#)

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